

AMC Stubs A-List as a Popular Culture Artifact

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COMM 2725: Popular Communication

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April 24th, 2026

AMC Stubs A-List is a subscription based moviegoing program launched by AMC Theatres in 2018. This loyalty and rewards program allows users to earn points on purchasing tickets and concessions, get free refills, and birthday gifts. AMC Stubs A-List is the highest tier of AMC's rewards programs and allows members to watch up to four movies a week in any format, including premium formats like IMAX and Dolby Cinema, for a monthly fee. This program entered the market after MoviePass collapsed and left an untapped space in the market. AMC filled this void with a more sustainable and successful model. Since the program launched the program has gained more than one million members and has reshaped the movie going experience (AMC Theaters, 2019).

A-List deserves to be recognized as a popular culture artifact because it aligns with definitions that Communications scholars like Stuart Hall and John Fiske have created. A-List also engages with materiality through several different spaces that can be experienced in everyday life. Fandom is alive and well for A-List expressed in communities, social media, identity and participation in the culture of cinema. A-List is significant because it represents a cultural struggle between fans and corporate, its ability to be seen materially, and the sheer amount of fans and volume of engagement for people who are fans of A-List.

Position in Popular Culture

AMC Stubs A-List can be recognized as popular culture through several frameworks that scholars use to define what popular culture is. Looking at A-List from a quantitative perspective you can see that there are around a million members meaning A-List is widely consumed by the public and there is widespread knowledge of A-List within the public. (Hall, 1981) calls the

market definition of popular culture “the things which are said to be ‘popular’ because masses of people listen to them, buy them, read them, consume them, and seem to enjoy them to the full.”

But A-List isn’t just something that many people enjoy and consume. Its influence and significance are much more than just the amount of users on the platform.

Fiske discusses that “popular culture is made by various formations of subordinated or disempowered people out of the resources, both discursive and material, that are provided by the social system that disempowers them” (Fiske, 1989). A-List provides the resources to “disempowered” people that can make watching movies or participating in cinema more accessible. Without AMC Stubs A-List some people wouldn’t be able to afford going to the movies. Without this subscription model existing paying full price for movies would be the only option. Full priced films are extremely expensive and you would be limited to a small number of films per year that you would be certain you enjoy. A-List allows members to see other films that they wouldn’t take a chance on if they were paying full price. It removes the barrier for movie fans to see smaller films and releases that they wouldn’t have been able to go to before. A-List allows for a broader range of participants in the movie going experience and to be able to participate in conversations around film. Fiske also argues that “if the cultural commodities or texts do not contain resources out of which the people can make their own meanings of their social relations and identities, they will be rejected and will fail in the marketplace” (Fiske 1989). A-List offers the opportunity for movie goers to form an identity and sense of belonging as someone who engages with film culture and shares bonds with other A-Listers.

However, A-List is a product produced by a corporation which is designed to earn AMC theaters more profit. It is an entity that wants to drive seat occupancy, concession revenue, and drive customer loyalty. This is a perfect example of a site of struggle in popular culture. Its an

entity that is dual natured, it is both commercially motivated, and motivated by creating a culturally relevant experience for its users. Hall describes this effect “There is no whole, authentic, autonomous ‘popular culture’ which lies outside of the field of force of the relations of cultural power and domination” (Hall 1981). A-List isn’t one extreme or the other, it exists in a space between corporate ideals and consumer autonomy and support. A-List additionally represents a second scale between being involved in everyday life and a particular way of life, and participation in artistic cinema. It structures hobbies and peoples weeks around seeing movies regularly but also provides access to cinematic art. While A-List starts as a way to save money on seeing movies, and that is a big draw for a lot of people, it doesn’t end with just saving money. It ends up becoming a part of your life and a part of your identity.

Another reason A-List is a part of pop culture is the fact that it is culturally relevant. Fiske says “relevance is central to popular culture, for it minimizes the difference between text and life”(Fiske 1989). A-List has been able to involve itself into everyday life. It's sort of made cinema a more impactful part of people’s lives. A-List members have inserted movie-going into their everyday routine. Going to the movies is less about a special occasion or once in a while thing, A-List has become a part of the everyday life for members. It's involved in their topics of conversation, it's a shared experience with other users, it's even become part of people’s identity. With this product being based off of a subscription model which people are already familiar with, it makes it easier for it to be seamlessly integrated into people's lives. A-List demonstrates that cinema is a larger necessity of cultural life and relevant with its audience and participants.

Engagement with Materiality

Storey argues that “popular culture always takes material form” and “a social practice that entangles meaning and materiality,” (Storey, 2018) and A-List demonstrates engagement with materiality on several levels. The physical theatrical space, the digital space, and even concessions are all ways that A-List engages with materiality. These objects don’t necessarily mean anything in isolation. They become meaningful when they are given meaning by their users and the practices they are used for. These aspects are aimed to be useful and catered towards frequent moviegoers, specifically Gen Z and Millennials who value experiences.

The physical space of the theater is a big part of the appeal for A-Listers. It's a space that feels like coming home and a space you can share with fellow members of the community. The meaning of the actual space changes in the eyes of A-Listers. It becomes a space where you can feel safe, where you experience one of your favorite activities in the world. Members continue to develop a relationship with the theater as they continue to go to movies. A-Listers enjoy and become even more familiar with the sights, the smells and the intimacy of the auditorium. Storey says “we interact with material objects in many ways: we produce and consume them, we exchange them, we talk about them and admire them, and we use them to say things about ourselves” (Storey, 2018). For A-List members the physical space of the theater isn’t just a place to watch movies, it produces a feeling of community and a sense of pride.

Premium seating and format screenings are a significant materiality aspect of A-List. A standard AMC IMAX screening in a major US city is around \$23. Being able to see IMAX and Dolby Cinema screenings for no extra cost provides something extra to the movie going experience. Movies are already a more cinematic and extraordinary experience. Adding a premium format like Dolby or IMAX on top of that makes the experience even better. These

physical aspects mean that you have a more premium movie watching experience. We assign more value to these screenings and it's more meaningful than a standard viewing experience.

The AMC app is also a central material artifact that is essential for A-Listers. Members need the app to browse when movies are showing and where, they are able to use it to reserve seats, track their rewards points, and actually manage their subscription. The choices within the app are made intentionally. It's designed to be easy to use with current showings being super easy to find and accessible to users. It wants users to easily interact with Stubs A-List and continue to be involved with their subscription. It structures point accumulation and visualization of different movie formats in a way that connects with fans and keeps them coming to the app. The app is also symbolic of the site of struggle, it's not a neutral tool for movie goers. It is designed to encourage repeat visits, more concession purchases, and wants to keep customers as loyal as possible to the brand.

Concessions are another aspect of A-List membership materiality. AMC offers many different food and beverage products and gives special discounts, free refills, and size upgrades to A-List members. The physical practice of purchasing food and drink at concessions help to reinforce your relationship with your membership. Popcorn is only associated with movies because movie goers give it that meaning. Popcorn's history and current understanding is a movie snack. Coca-Cola beverages are also associated with movies and given the meaning of the movie drink. These meanings are so ingrained in society that one commercial that plays before every movie features popcorn and a coke. Concessions can also represent another site of struggle where consumers feel like they are getting a deal on their food with points or because their membership is a good deal they are more willing to spend on concessions. But this is operating in the interest of the dominant wanting to earn more money for the AMC corporation.

Expressions and Manifestations of Fandom

Fandom around AMC Stubs A-List is a little bit different than what most scholars are typically studying. Usually we see fandom surrounding a specific text, person, character, franchise, or actor. A-List obviously isn't one character or film, but it's a way for users to access some of their favorite films and build community with one another. This does not make it any less worthy of having fans or being a representation of fan identity. Jenkins suggests that fans are "active producers and manipulators of meanings" who "construct their cultural and social identity through borrowing and inflecting mass cultural images" (Jenkins, 1992). A-List members are doing this actively. They use the program's access to develop deeper relationships with the culture of cinema and are publicly expressing these relationships. A-List is both a pop culture artifact that has its own fandom, and an infrastructure that can help produce and sustain other fandoms. This creates what Jenkins calls a "participatory culture" which is an environment in which media consumption is transformed into something that is embedded socially in society. A-List can help lower the barriers to expression, and provide the ability to engage with media and share a social connection with others.

The video essay *The Cult of AMC Stubs A-List* captures the fandom of AMC Stubs A-List to the fullest extent. In the video Miller describes how members of A-List develop a real relationship with the program. They share with their friends and family how amazing of a deal the program is and its genuine enthusiasm. A lot of users say it pays for itself if you see two movies a month. Most users are seeing more than two movies a month so it's an even better deal for them. The word "cult" is used lovingly but in a way that makes a lot of sense. The word cult,

when used in the context of fandom, usually is reserved for fans of a specific text. A-List has generated that kind of affection in its users.

The biggest visible online community focused on A-List is the subreddit r/AMCsAList which has 120,000 members who discuss anything and everything associated with A-List. They talk about subscription strategies, film recommendations, predictions, policy changes and any new knowledge about the A-List membership. This is an example of what Jenkins calls a participatory community. While there isn't as much in depth creation from fans on this subreddit as there would be for a traditional artifact this is still a large community producing new content based off of A-List. Jenkins also says fans "speak from a position of collective identity, to forge an alliance with a community of others in defense of tastes which, as a result, cannot be read as totally aberrant or idiosyncratic."

Tiktok has recently emerged as a platform for fan expression of AMC A-List. A viral video by creator Ace Honea jokes about how fans of the A-List membership can behave. The video exaggerates how much A-List members are truly fans of the platform, but it does show that users are enthusiastic about the platform and share that enthusiasm with others. People in the comments of this video resonated with the sentiment and were sharing their own thoughts about being A-List members. Booth argues that fan practices involve "reifying" fandom which is making identity visible and material through enactment (Booth, 2013). Fans posting about A-List on Tiktok are making their fan identity known to the public and are showing off that they are fans of A-List. Another platform that is used in companion with A-List is Letterboxd.

Letterboxed is a platform where users can rate and comment on recent films they have seen, rank their own top movies, and connect with other users. Letterboxed provides a really unique social outlet that amplifies the engagement with A-List. This intermix of A-List and Letterboed

represents Fiske's completion of popular culture "Popular texts are inadequate in themselves they are never self-sufficient structures of meanings...they are completed only when taken up by people and inserted into their everyday culture" Letterboxed provides a space for A-List to have more meaning and be implemented into everyday culture.

Conclusion

AMC Stubs A-List is a part of popular culture because of its wide consumption and influence, sites of struggle, identity building, and the strong role it plays in users' lives. A-List meets definitions produced by Hall, Storey, and Fiske, especially as a site of struggle. Stubs A-List also encompasses a wide array of material objects. Physical theaters, premium viewing experiences, the app, and concessions all have meaning because of A-List and A-List users. Fandom of AMC Stubs A-List is expressed through their subreddit community, TikTok videos, Letterboxed and Youtube creators. A-List is a cultural phenomenon and artifact that has been able to endure the test of time since its conception in 2018. It values the collective experience of watching a film in theaters and then connecting as a community about the films you are seeing. Being able to share the experience with other viewers makes movies all the more special. The fact that the AMC corporation is producing this artifact is a paradox in popular culture. Simultaneously the producers of the product want you to buy the product, but the users want to claim it as their own and create a different meaning for the artifact.

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